3.2 Fertilizers

Apart from water, sunlight and air, certain nutrients are also needed for the growth of plants. We know that the plants get their nutrients from the soil.

Nitrogen (N), Phosphorous (P) and Potassium (K) are the three important nutrients among the various nutrients needed for the growth of plants. These three are called as **Principal Nutrients.**

The table given below depicts the quantity of elements absorbed by certain common plants.

Crop	Yield per hectare (kg) (Approxi-mate)	Nitrogen (kg)	Phosphorous (kg)	Potassium (kg)
Rice	2,240	34	22	67
Corn	2,016	36	20	39
Sugarcane	67,200	90	17	202
Groundnut	1,904	78	22	45

❖ What would happen to the nutrient content of the soil, if the field is farmed continuously?

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❖ How could we resend these nutrients back to the soil?

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Fertilizers are organic or inorganic materials that we add to the soil to provide one or more nutrients to the soil.

Fertilizers given to plants can be classified into two. They are organic and inorganic fertilizers.

Organic fertilizers



Fertilizers containing only plant or animal-based materials or those synthesized by micro-organisms are called organic fertilizers.

These fertilizers can be prepared easily. This type of fertilizers are economical. **(e.g) Vermi compost, compost.**

Inorganic fertilizers

The fertilizers prepared by using natural elements by making them undergo chemical changes in the factories are called inorganic fertilizers. **(e.g) Urea, Ammonium sulphate and Super phosphate.**

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